

TENTATIVE RULING

Case: Burnham-Bruce v. AWTs, LLC
Case No. CV2025-3059

Hearing Date: August 11, 2026 **Department Thirteen** **9:00 a.m.**

Defendant AWTs, LLC's renewed petition to compel arbitration and request for stay of proceedings is **GRANTED**. (Code Civ. Proc., § 1281 et seq.) "A party seeking to compel arbitration of a dispute bears the burden of proving the existence of an arbitration agreement, and the party opposing arbitration bears the burden of proving any defense, such as unconscionability." (*Jenks v. DLA Piper Rudnick Gray Cary US LLP* (2015) 243 Cal.App.4th 1, 8.) A defendant satisfies its "initial burden by attaching to their petition a copy of the purported arbitration agreement bearing [the plaintiff's] electronic signature." (*Espejo v. Southern California Permanente Medical Group* (2016) 246 Cal.App.4th 1047, 1060.) Once the plaintiff challenges "the validity of that signature in his opposition, defendants [are] then required to establish by a preponderance of the evidence that the signature was authentic." (*Id.* at pp. 1060-1061; *Iyere v. Wise Auto Group* (2023) 87 Cal.App.5th 747, 754-755; see also *Ruiz v. Moss Bros. Auto Group, Inc.* (2014) 232 Cal.App.4th 836, 843-844.)

The Court finds that defendant satisfied its initial burden by providing a copy of the arbitration agreement with plaintiff's electronic signature. (Edmunds decl., ¶¶ 2-4, Exhibit A.) In the opposition, plaintiff Chenel Burnham-Bruce does not challenge the validity of her signature. (See Opposition, pp. 7-8; Burnham-Bruce decl., ¶¶ 5-9.) Accordingly, defendant has shown the existence of an arbitration agreement between the parties. (*Espejo, supra*, 246 Cal.App.4th at p. 1060; see also Edmunds decl., ¶¶ 6-11, Exhibits B & C.)

In opposing arbitration, plaintiff has failed to show that the arbitration agreement is procedurally unconscionable. (*Jenks, supra*, 243 Cal.App.4th at p. 8; *Rosenthal v. Great Western Fin. Securities Corp.* (1996) 14 Cal.4th 394, 413.) Specifically, the signed arbitration agreement states: "the Parties represent that they have been given the opportunity to fully review, understand and negotiate the terms of this Agreement." (Edmunds decl., ¶ 3, Exhibit A, p. 4.) It further states: "I understand that I have the right to decline the opportunity to participate in mutual arbitration and to reject this Agreement if I so choose without affecting my eligibility for employment or, alternatively, continued employment, by the Company." (*Ibid.*; see also Burnham-Bruce decl., ¶¶ 3-10.) As plaintiff has not established procedural unconscionability, the Court does not reach substantive unconscionability. (*Kinney v. United HealthCare Services, Inc.* (1999) 70 Cal.App.4th 1322, 1329.)

As to the representative PAGA claims, this matter is **STAYED**, pending the outcome of plaintiff's individual claims in arbitration. (Code Civ. Proc., § 1281.4; *Adolph v. Uber Technologies, Inc.* (2023) 14 Cal.5th 1104, 1114 & 1123-1124; *Franco v. Arakelian Enterprises, Inc.* (2015) 234 Cal.App.4th 947, 966.) The Court sets a status hearing for **February 11, 2027**, at 9:00 a.m. in Department Thirteen.

The notice of motion does not provide notice of this Court's tentative ruling system as required by Local Rule 11.2(b). Counsel for moving party, or the moving party if unrepresented by counsel, is ordered to notify the opposing party or parties immediately of the tentative ruling system.

If no hearing is requested, and no party appears at the hearing, this tentative ruling is effective immediately. No formal order pursuant to California Rules of Court, rule 3.1312 or further notice is required.